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Building AI that works

From faster creation to real-world value

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The first version comes faster

Agents and vibe coding make ideas tangible sooner

Gemini 4 Argon



Still unanswered questions:

Who needs it?

Does it fit their work?

Can we trust what happens when they use it?

AI capability became cheaper to access

280×

lower inference cost

at GPT-3.5-level performance

November 2022 to October 2024

More than 280-fold. Capability-level comparison, not total product cost.

Stanford HAI, AI Index 2025

Agents are changing build versus buy

32%

skipped a software purchase because coding agents enabled an internal build

Share of survey respondents, 2026

McKinsey, The state of AI in 2026, 25 August 2026

Productivity gains and financial impact differ

80%

report improved individual productivity

37%

report positive enterprise EBIT impact

Different measures. Self-reported survey findings.

McKinsey, The state of AI in 2026, 25 August 2026

As builders, we need to follow the work through.

What actually improves for the person or the business?

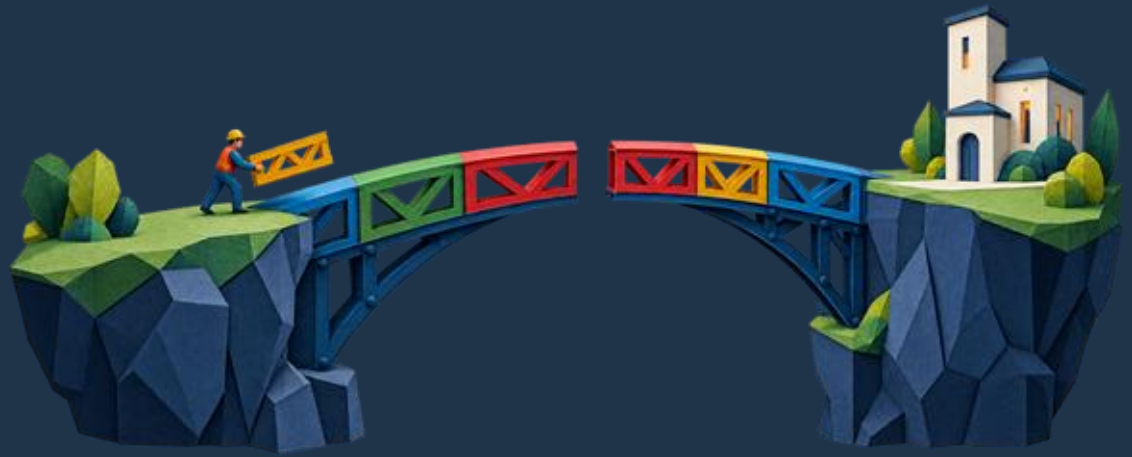
That is the result we should design for and measure.

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A working prototype is the beginning

Working prototype

Useful product



Value, experience, and the harness

Value

What becomes better?

Experience

What does the user need to do?

Harness

What makes it dependable?

One customer, one return

“I need to return these shoes.”

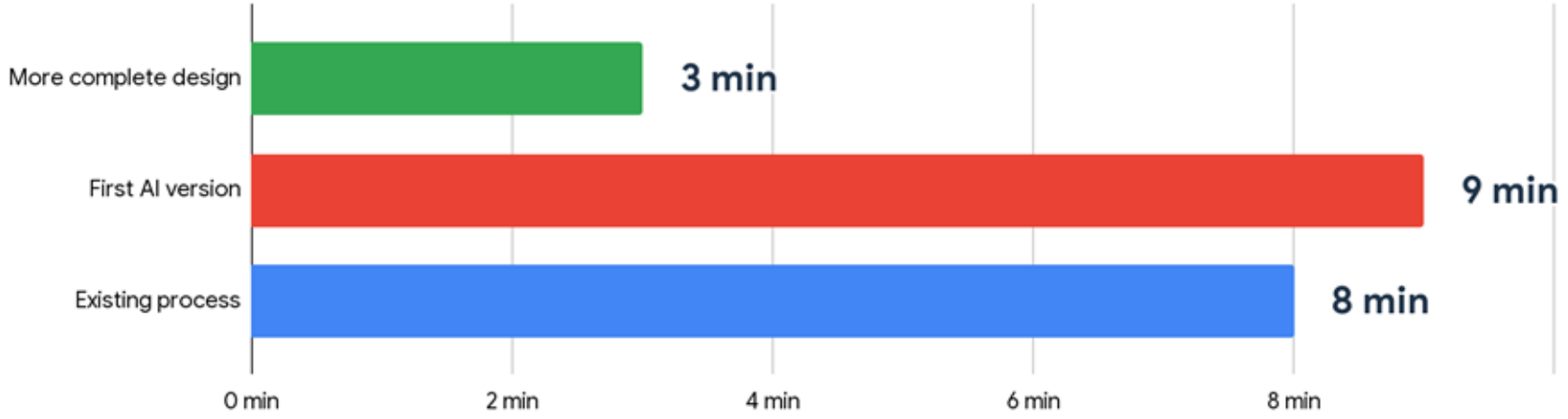


Success: a valid return with a confirmed pickup

Fictional product example

The user pays for every extra step

Total customer effort



Illustrative assumptions, not measured outcomes

AI during development and execution

While building

AI assists the developer

Code review
Tests and integration checks

While running

AI acts for the user

Live context and permissions
State and verified actions

The harness around the model

Example: ADK on Google Cloud

Context

Policy and order

State

What happened



Tools

Permitted actions

Execution controls

Limits and recovery

Evaluation and observability

Small errors compound across a workflow

95%

success per required step

$$0.95^{10} \approx 0.60$$

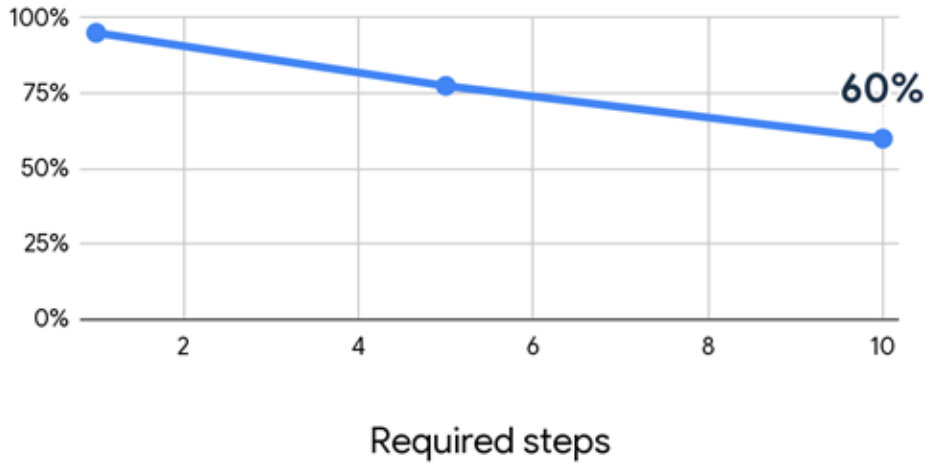


Illustration: independent steps, equal success rate, every step required, no recovery

Takeaway:

Start with the simplest workflow that can complete the task. Add complexity when you have evidence that it helps.

Widespread use still needs verification

90%

use AI at work

30%

report little or no trust in AI-generated code

Survey respondent groups may overlap

Google Cloud, DORA 2025, 23 September 2025

Evidence for a useful product

Task completion

Did it finish correctly?

User effort

How much work remains?

Repeat use

Do people choose it again?

Cost per successful task

Can we sustain it?

The economics continue after launch

≈20%

say operating costs constrained AI usage

Cost per successful task

Total operating cost
÷
Successfully completed tasks

Gemini models: match the task

McKinsey, The state of AI in 2026, 25 August 2026

Cheaper experiments create room to learn

One experiment can test one important assumption



Your build today

Who is it for? - Name a person

What becomes better? - Make it concrete

How will you prove it? - What you measure

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Building AI that works

A useful outcome.
A dependable experience.

Road to DevFest: Fork, Build & Merge

Sources and definitions

Stanford HAI

AI Index 2025. Inference cost at GPT-3.5-level performance, Nov 2022 to Oct 2024.

2025 AI Index Report

McKinsey

State of AI 2026, 25 Aug 2026. 32%, 80%, 37%, and approximately 20% are self-reported.

The state of AI in 2026: On the road to ROI

References and illustrative examples

Google Cloud DORA 2025 and ADK evaluation

DORA 2025: adoption, trust, and the surrounding engineering system

ADK: final responses and tool-use trajectories